

*Couponing* featured shoppers who were blatantly using counterfeit coupons. In October of 2011, one of the shoppers used thirty-four free 12-pack Quilted Northern toilet paper coupons. Those coupons turned out to be counterfeit. The Gelson's store that accepted the coupons discovered this when they were denied payment for them. The teen shopper's mother had to come in and repay the store for over four hundred dollars' worth of toilet paper, but viewers never saw that on television.

Then in a 2012 episode, a Pennsylvania shopper used two hundred coupons for free bottles of Tide. Those coupons also turned out to be fraudulent. Both Jill Cataldo and the CIC were instrumental in bringing these counterfeit coupons to light, and yet the TLC producers had little more to say about the problem than claiming they had no responsibility for the coupons their featured shoppers used. Where did the shoppers get their fake coupons? While not verified, they likely bought them, maybe from someone like Robin Ramirez of Phoenix, Arizona. After an eight-week undercover investigation, in July of 2012, police raided the homes of three Phoenix area women, seizing forty million dollars' worth of very realistic-looking counterfeit coupons. They also seized two million dollars' worth of assets from the three homes. The women allegedly purchased the fake coupons overseas and then resold them through a website, SavvyShopperSite.com, and through auctions on eBay.

When it comes to counterfeiting coupons, the advent of the Internet and Internet-printed (IP) coupons brought its own share of problems. The first IP coupons were a PDF file that could be printed over and over. It took me awhile to trust the IP coupons when they were first introduced. It seemed